

**THIS WAS
TOMORROW**
*IS THIS THE
FUTURE WE WERE
DREAMING OF?*

A PROJECT BY
ENRICO POLICARDO



Supported using public funding by
**ARTS COUNCIL
ENGLAND**

About the Project

Official project description.

For press, listings and partner websites.

This Was Tomorrow: Is This the Future We Were Dreaming Of? is a long-term audio-visual investigation by artist and photographer Enrico Policardo into community-led housing across the UK - cohousing, Community Land Trusts, cooperative living, retrofit and repair.

It looks at places that are functioning in the present, without framing them as models or solutions. The question throughout is not “does this work?” but something closer to: what futures are still imaginable from where we are now? The title holds the distance between what was promised and what is lived, and the work tries to make that distance visible - not as failure, but as the actual terrain of collective life in the making.

The investigation began in 2022, documenting endangered council estates in London and the utopian ideals embedded in their material form. A residency at ESAD IDEA in Porto, made possible by the work of David Marques (Devity

Studio), shifted the focus - from documenting the past to watching the present, and how places actually function across different models of collective ownership, adaptation, repair, resilience and grassroots ingenuity.

This Arts Council England-funded phase reaches across England - from London and the south coast to Cornwall, and up into the North and West.

Supported by Arts Council England through the Developing Your Creative Practice (DYCP) scheme, with the support of Simon Vickery (Open House Festival Programme Manager), writer and photographer Thaddeus Zupancic (London Estates: Modernist Council Housing 1946-1981), and architectural historian Judith Martin, co-author of the original This Was Tomorrow publication.



ROPERS WALK

IS THIS THE FUTURE WE WERE DREAMING OF ?

Home-making

Home isn't only the physical roof and dwelling - it includes community, living well, and a vision of the future that isn't what I've come to define as the marry-mortgage-die structure. That isn't a criticism but an acknowledgement of what capitalism has done in nuclearising the family, creating false myths of independence, whether financial or of resources, all in favour of a system that is not built around the real needs, the needs of human beings, but around the needs of capital: the dehumanising idea of wealth that has been brought onto the main stage by centuries of elites pushing their own idea of what constitutes a good life. A life of belonging, and of having to defend it from hypothetical enemies.

The history of humanity - not the one written down in books, that one is the history of power, not the history of The People - says the opposite. People have always come together when facing practical challenges, hardships and obstacles, but also to celebrate, to procreate, and to feel a sense of belonging. That's what people have always done - not those surrounded by moats and crocodiles and the suffocating fear of losing their possessions.

A field

Here's the thing all of this protects. I'm not trying to crystallise places in the memory of what they were or are. I'm trying to preserve the opportunity a place holds - to keep a field a field.

Someone who put me in touch with one of the communities I visited told me "It's just a field, there's nothing to see". There was everything to see: an open ground where people could still decide what happens next. What a privilege to witness that. How many of you have been able to do so? To be somewhere where the soil is so rich that just by walking on it you feel nourished, enriched, more resilient than when you first arrived?

Care

Care and intelligence, choices made for the common good - not because I hold some high morality, but because the common good is the only thing that gives back without your having to ask whether it does. Made with the future in mind. Not for the now, but to keep future freedoms open rather than extracted.

This project, above all, is a reminder, mostly to myself. That we can. We're echo-systems: we rely and thrive on each other, on the reverberations we all generate, and we suffer from it too. Dreaming better futures isn't an idle process, an elitist indulgence in speculative horizons. Dreaming is the action that makes futures happen - or rather, that unlocks them.

The work goes outside, where everyone already is, and it's allowed to fade, wear out, decompose, be forgotten. A vibrant orange turning into a pale yellow. Watching something fade is in itself an act of care, an acceptance of passing time.

Things perish, and it's fine. We celebrate and embalm youth and feel bad when anything ages, dents or dims. In this fear there's the quintessence of the era we are living: the fear of losing, of missing out, of being replaced by someone or something faster, more efficient, more attractive, more hungry, more desperate.

Subtraction

I take the faces out of the recordings. I take the frame, the glass, the mount off the print and glue it to the wall.

Subtraction from the false perfection of a file - clean, inhuman, frictionless - and back toward the imperfection of the real world, which might be the only perfection there is. Bitmapping does this by misbehaving: the computer introduces its own noise and error, and never the same way twice, or so I like to believe.

I don't save the result. Every time I need a print I run the reduction again, and every run comes out differently, so no two prints have ever been the same and none can be repeated. It's the opposite of an edition: not one image copied many times, but one source that reinvents itself on every pass.

I like what the error finds: the grain, the wear, the things that don't resolve cleanly. When the result is partly out of my hands, it takes away the burden of deciding everything. I don't much trust the idea that we author our own outcomes anyway.

People are not absent from this work - they're everywhere in it, digging the soil, foraging, planning, going to protests, dreaming.

They're just not inside the frame: they are around it.

This project is about imagination - about fuelling it - and imagination needs a gap to work in. Like reading: the words on the page are only a tool, and you supply the colours, the faces, the smells.

Enrico Policardo
Winchester, August 2026



Noch-Nicht

About the author

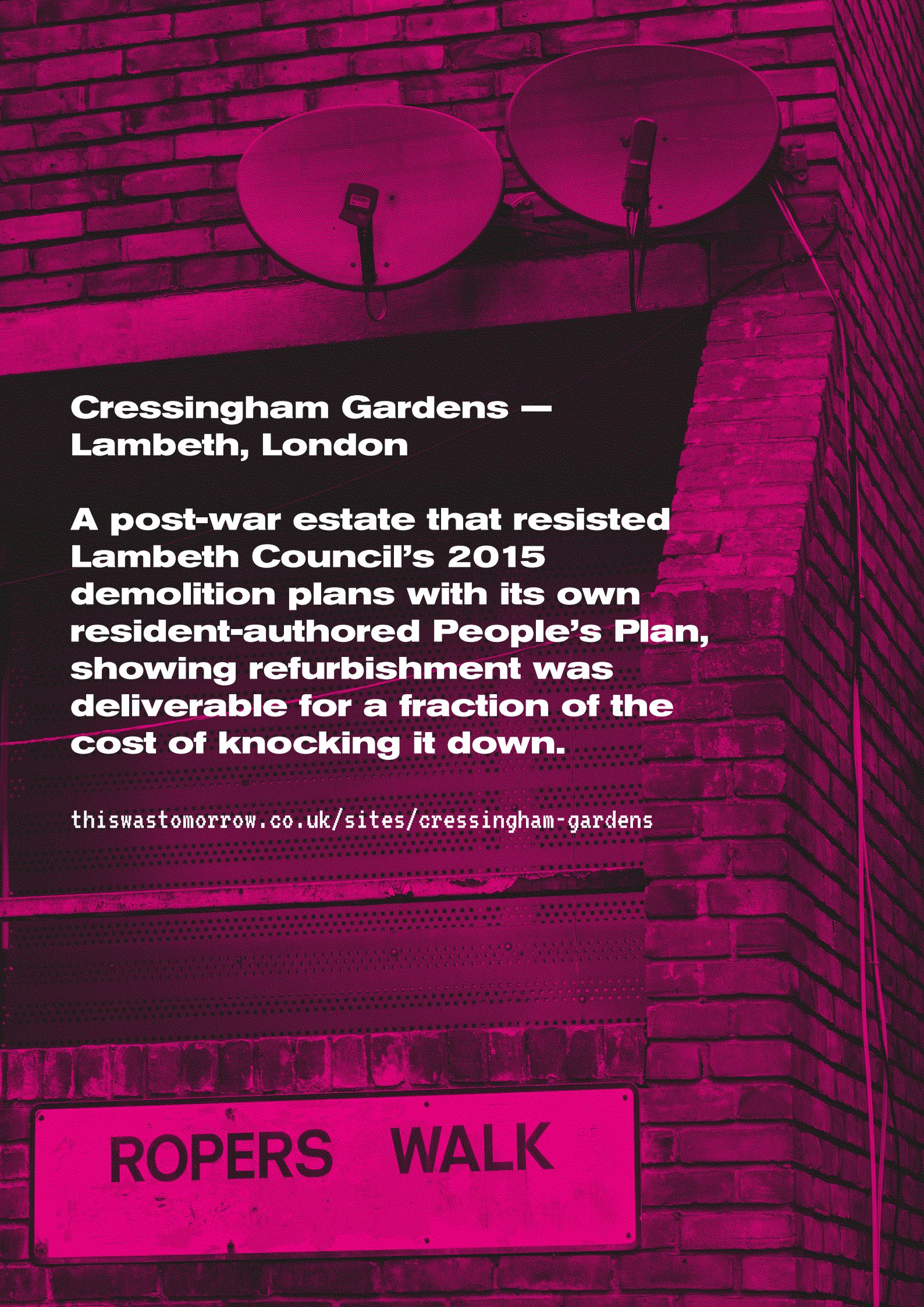
Enrico Policardo

Photographer and artist based in London. His work examines how systems of power organise everyday life, housing and who gets to shape it, waste and what a consumer economy throws away and the contested ground of borders. Creative Director of ReThinkable Festival on the Italy-Slovenia border (Nova Gorica / Gorizia, European Capital of Culture 2024-2026) and an Affiliate Research Fellow at the University of Nova Gorica.

This Was Tomorrow, supported by Arts Council England, documents communities across the UK who have taken housing into their own hands.

enricopolicardo.com

voices and places

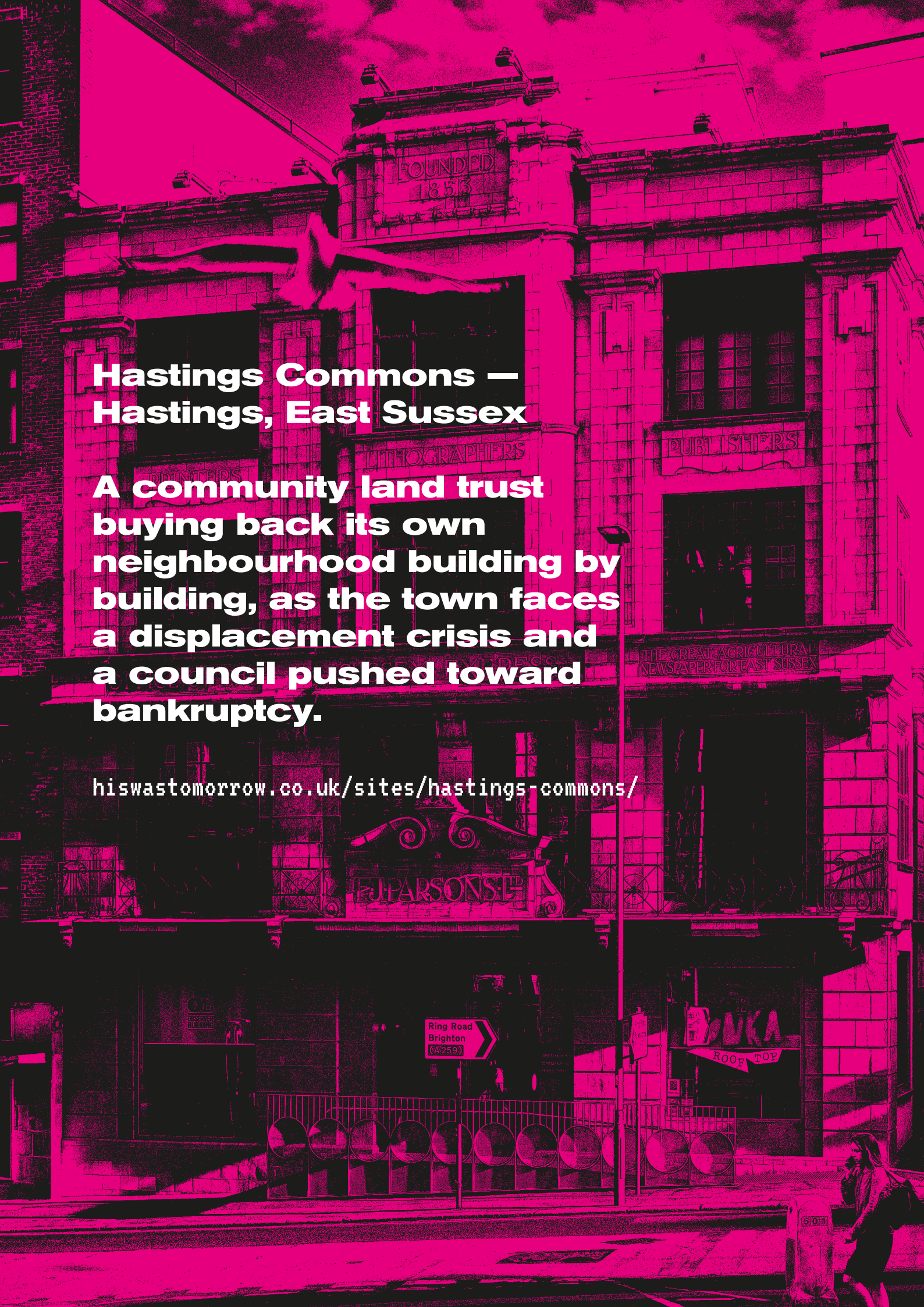
A photograph of a brick wall with two satellite dishes mounted on it. A street sign for 'ROPERS WALK' is visible at the bottom. The image has a magenta tint.

Cressingham Gardens — Lambeth, London

**A post-war estate that resisted
Lambeth Council's 2015
demolition plans with its own
resident-authored People's Plan,
showing refurbishment was
deliverable for a fraction of the
cost of knocking it down.**

thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/cressingham-gardens

ROPERS WALK



Hastings Commons — Hastings, East Sussex

**A community land trust
buying back its own
neighbourhood building by
building, as the town faces
a displacement crisis and
a council pushed toward
bankruptcy.**

hiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/hastings-commons/

A photograph of the interior of a workshop, identified as Tinker's Bubble. The space is filled with various tools, equipment, and materials. On the left, a workbench holds a power drill, a saw, and other tools. A large window in the center provides natural light. To the right, there are shelves and more equipment, including a large metal container. The overall atmosphere is one of a well-used, functional workspace.

Tinker's Bubble — Norton sub Hamdon, Somerset

**An off-grid, fossil-fuel-free
community that has worked 40
acres of Somerset woodland by
hand and horse for over thirty
years, since 1994.**

thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/tinkers-bubble/

10kg

Miele
PROFESSIONAL

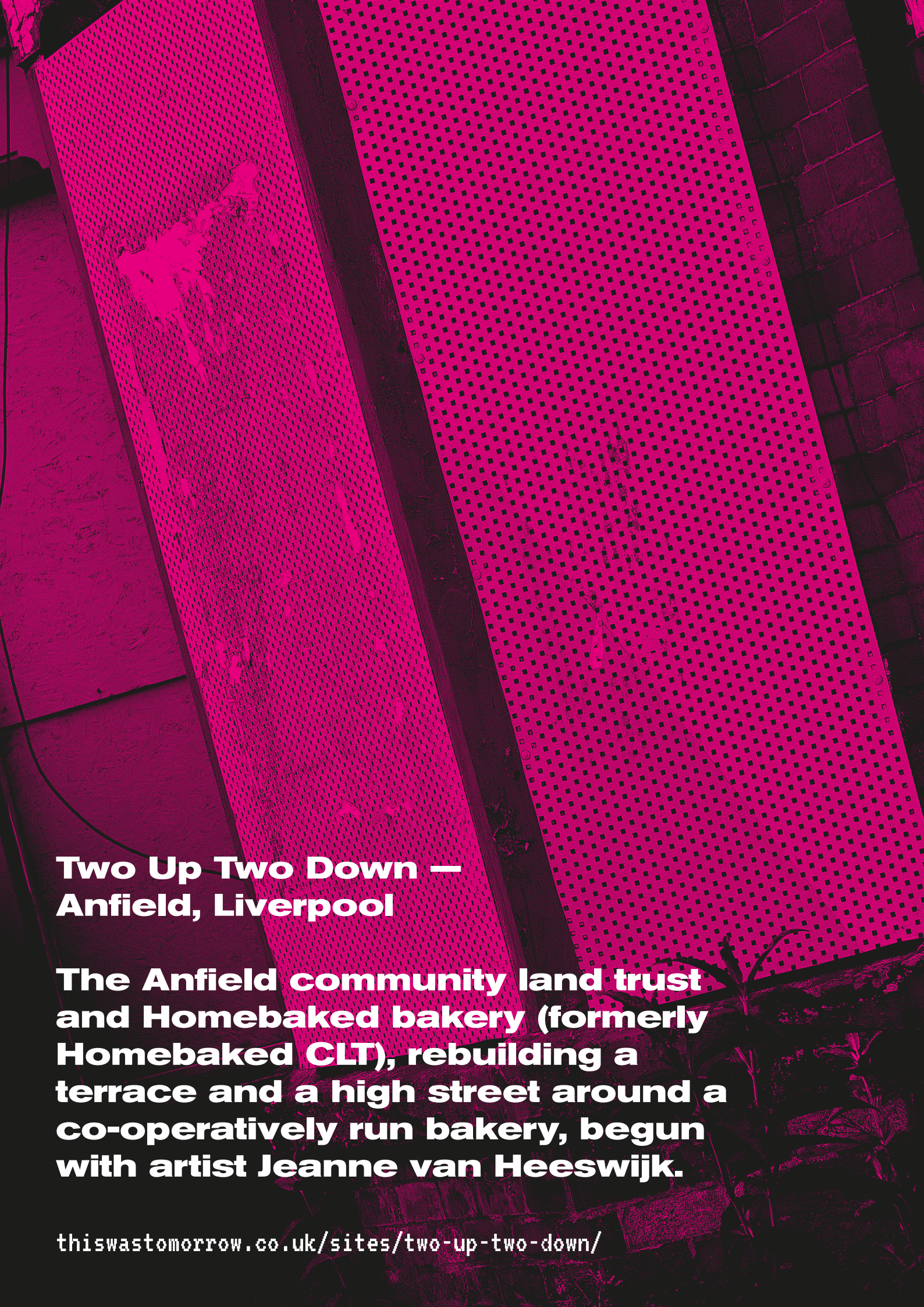
In memory of
June Birch



Kitty's Launderette — Anfield, Liverpool

**A community-owned
launderette and social
space reviving an old
neighbourhood model -
award-winning, and now
expanding by crowdfunder.**

thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/kittys/



Two Up Two Down — Anfield, Liverpool

The Anfield community land trust and Homebaked bakery (formerly Homebaked CLT), rebuilding a terrace and a high street around a co-operatively run bakery, begun with artist Jeanne van Heeswijk.

thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/two-up-two-down/

Vo New Build

Granby Four Streets — Liverpool

The Toxteth community land trust born from a residents' fight against demolition, who took derelict Victorian terraces into community ownership and won the 2015 Turner Prize with the Assemble collective.

thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/granby/



**Calder Valley Community
Land Trust —
Hebden Bridge &
Todmorden**

**A land trust delivering
permanently affordable,
retrofitted homes in a
valley where secure low-
rent housing is scarce -
its first home let to a local
family at social rent.**

thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/calder-valley/

OWCH / New Ground — High Barnet, London

**The UK's first senior
cohousing community, built
by a group of older women
on the site of a former
convent and designed with
them by architects Pollard
Thomas Edwards.**

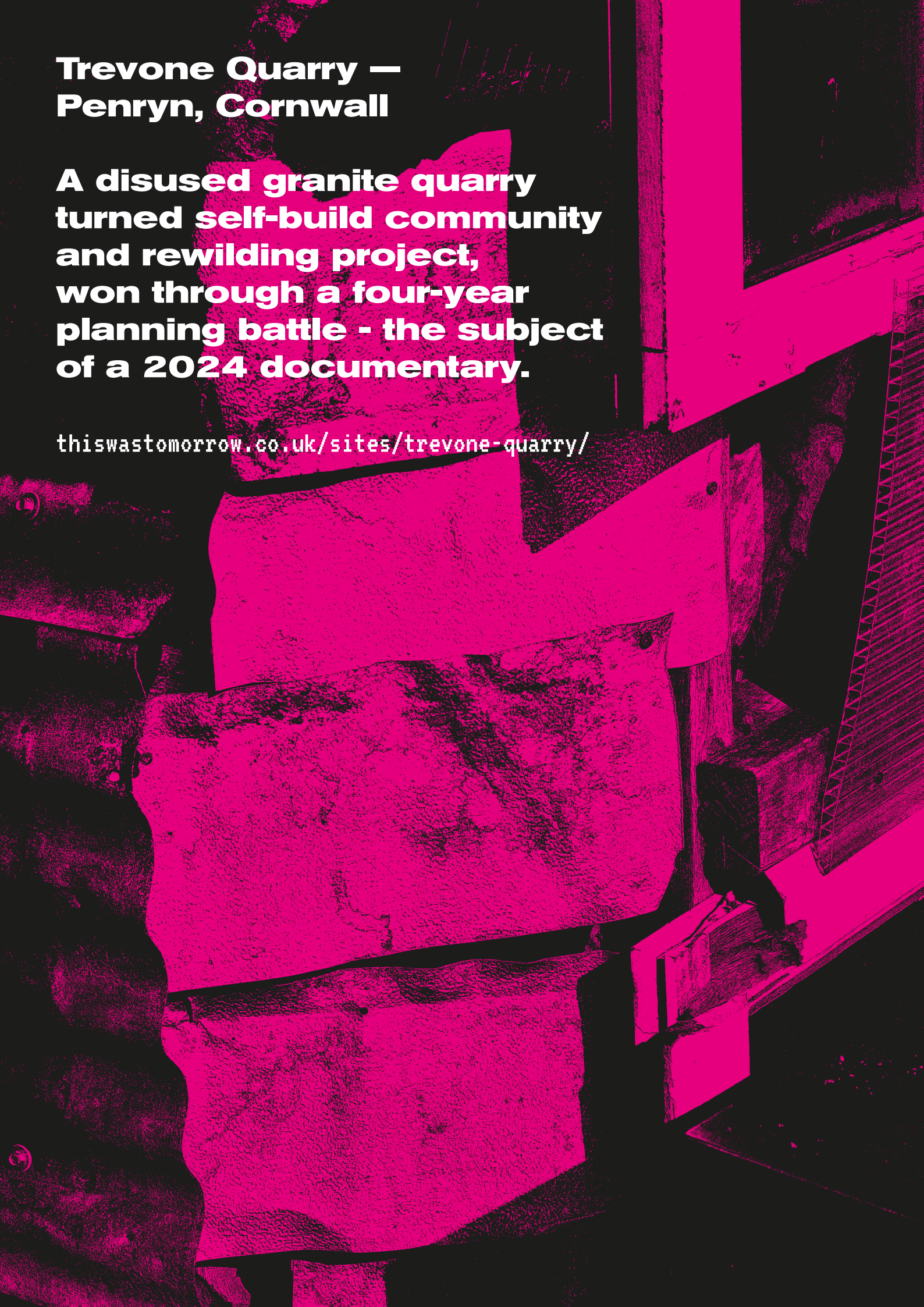
thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/owch-new-ground/

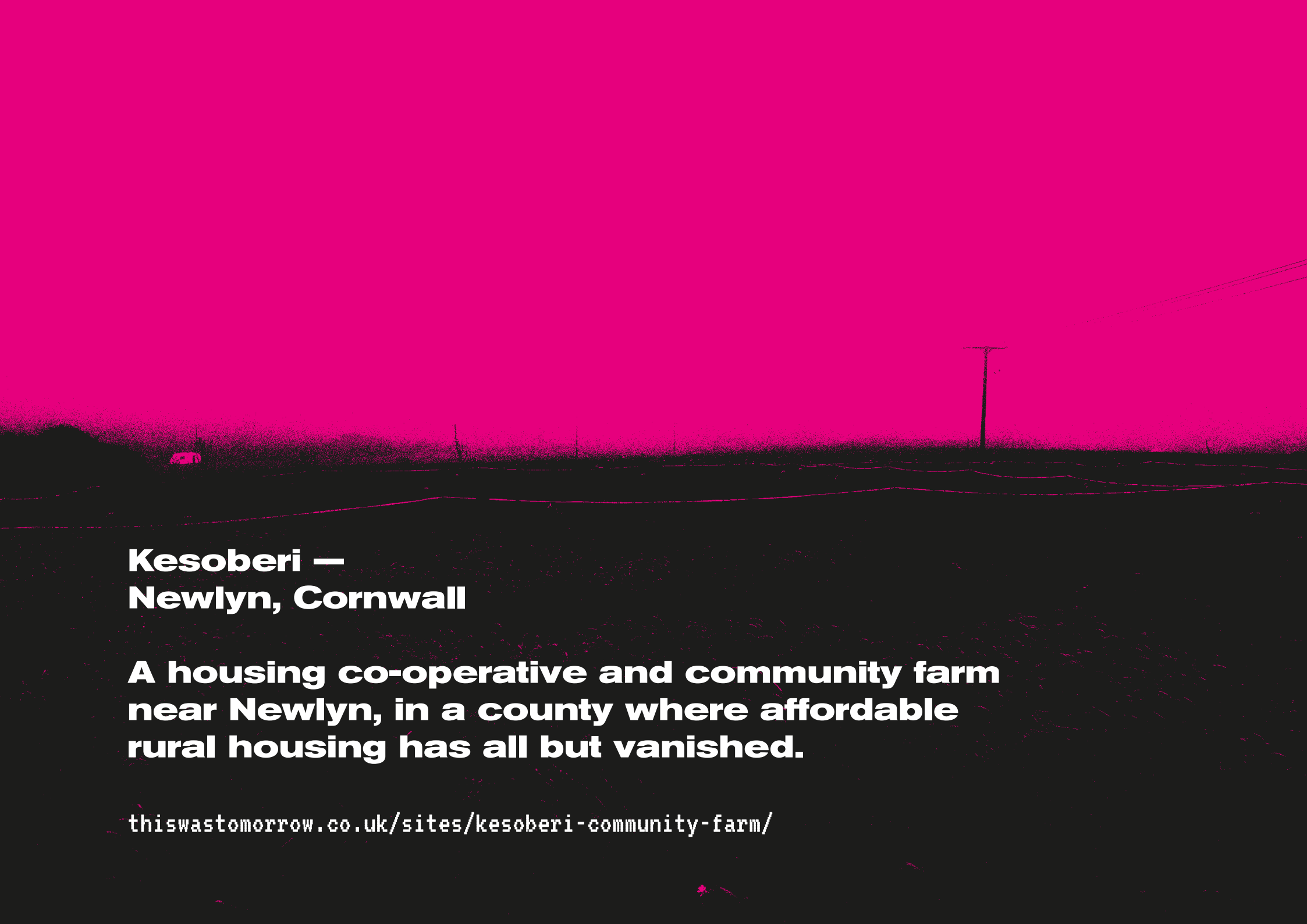


Trevone Quarry — Penryn, Cornwall

**A disused granite quarry
turned self-build community
and rewilding project,
won through a four-year
planning battle - the subject
of a 2024 documentary.**

thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/trevone-quarry/





Kesoberi — Newlyn, Cornwall

**A housing co-operative and community farm
near Newlyn, in a county where affordable
rural housing has all but vanished.**

thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/kesoberi-community-farm/

**Treneere Estate / Whole
Again Communities —
Penzance, Cornwall**

**A community-building
organisation working on the
Treneere estate in Penzance,
growing food and social
infrastructure.**

thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/treneere-estate/

A wooden signpost stands in a lush garden. The top horizontal board of the signpost has the word 'UTOPIA' painted in large, dark, hand-painted capital letters. Below it, on a narrower board, the word 'LILAC' is painted in smaller, dark, hand-painted capital letters. The signpost is surrounded by dense green foliage, including bushes and trees, with sunlight filtering through the leaves.

LILAC — Leeds

**Low Impact Living Affordable
Community: a co-operative
of straw-bale homes with an
income-linked affordability model,
co-founded by urban geographer
Paul Chatterton.**

thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/lilac/